The right questions to ask about a data center project

At a public meeting, at the counter or in a council session: these questions can be asked as they are. They follow the five pillars of our scoring grid.

ENERGY

« How much grid power are you requesting, in megawatts, and where does the connection request stand? »
Connected power tells the real size of the project better than the building's footprint.

« Will the heat produced be recovered — by whom, and under what signed contract? »
Heat recovery is often announced, rarely contracted.

« What energy efficiency (PUE — the ratio of total electricity consumed to the share that actually powers the servers) will be measured and published once the site operates? »
A figure promised before construction commits to nothing until it is measured and published.

WATER

« How will the site be cooled, and how much water will it use per year, drawn from where — drinking network, borehole, river? »
Depending on the cooling technique, water use ranges from near zero to considerable.

« What happens under a drought order: will the site reduce its withdrawals, and is that in writing? »
Better to know the answer before the crisis than during it.

« Is the water commitment in the permitting documents, or only in the project's communications? »
Only what is written in the official permitting documents is enforceable.

LAND & BIODIVERSITY

« How much land will be artificialized, and on what kind of ground — brownfield, farmland, natural area? »
An industrial brownfield and farmland do not carry the same cost for the municipality.

« How does the project fit the local land-sobriety or no-net-land-take objectives (in France: the "zero net artificialization" target, 2021 Climate and Resilience Act)? »
Hectares consumed here will be missing elsewhere — housing, facilities, activity.

« Are protected or inventoried natural areas nearby (in France: Natura 2000, ZNIEFF), and what does the impact study say? »
The answer can be checked online; hesitation is a signal.

« What is planned for the site's end of life — dismantling, restoration — and who pays? »
Without an end-of-life plan, a building this size becomes the municipality's burden.

LOCAL IMPACT

« How many permanent on-site jobs once built — not counting construction jobs? »
The two figures are often blended, and the construction one always flatters.

« What noise level at the property line, day and night, and how often will the backup generators be tested? »
Cooling noise is permanent, testing noise is recurring — both can be measured and written into the filing.

« What tax revenue, and for whom exactly — your municipality, or a wider authority? »
Revenue announced "for the territory" does not necessarily reach your municipality.

« During construction: how many trucks per day, on which roads, for how many months? »
Construction lasts years; it is the most immediate impact for residents.

TRANSPARENCY & GOVERNANCE

« Who carries the project: the local company created for the occasion, or the group behind it — and who will answer in ten years? »
Projects are often carried by dedicated entities; today's contact may disappear.

« What data will be published during operation — measured electricity, water, efficiency — and how often? »
A publication commitment can be verified; a spoken promise cannot.

« Is a monitoring body bringing together officials and residents planned, and with what role? »
Dialogue after commissioning is the first lever for commitments to be kept.

« Where can the full permitting documents be consulted, and when does the public get to weigh in? »
Those dates open your rights — missing them closes remedies (see Rights and timeline — France).

An unanswered question is not a failure: note it, date it, ask again in writing. That is exactly what our grid does: what is not publicly documented shows up in the confidence level (high, medium or low) attached to every grade.